

When to summarize and when to reset the context

The two commands

	<code>/compact</code>	<code>/clear</code>
History	Replaced by a summary	Reset in the current conversation
Session thread	Maintained	Broken
Context effect	History replaced by a summary; amount varies	Conversation history reset
When to use	Mid-task	Topic change

`/compact` compresses without cutting the thread, `/clear` starts from scratch. Neither is universally better, the choice depends on the situation.

Context decisions

Use `/context` to inspect usage. Compact when useful history has become bulky; clear when changing topics or when a fresh conversation is more useful. No single occupancy percentage predicts response quality. Save decisions, acceptance criteria and unfinished work before either operation.

When to use `/compact`

Ideal situations:

- Task in progress with useful historical context
- Long session on the same module or feature
- You need to remember decisions made

```
/compact
```

Claude replaces conversation history with a summary. The space recovered and the details preserved vary; check `/context` and keep critical state in files.

When to use `/clear`

Ideal situations:

- Complete change of topic or project
- Context polluted by many errors and failed attempts
- Session going badly, generating inconsistencies

```
/clear
```

The conversation starts fresh; applicable instructions are loaded again. Saved sessions remain resumable. Start with a focused prompt and the necessary context files.

"Summarize from Here": The third option

Via `/rewind` (or `Esc + Esc`), you can select a specific point in the history and choose "Summarize from here". Claude summarizes only from that point, keeping prior context intact.

```
Esc + Esc → select a checkpoint → "Summarize from here"
```

More precise than global `/compact`, useful when only the end of the session is verbose.

Quick comparison

Situation	Command
Bulky history, same task	<code>/compact</code>

Situation	Command
New topics after a dense session	<code>/clear</code>
Verbose end of session to clean up	Rewind → Summarize
Useful history worth summarizing	<code>/compact</code>
Repeated confusion, fresh start needed	<code>/clear</code>

What `/compact` does NOT preserve

The summary generated by `/compact` is a synthesis. It may simplify technical nuances or implicit decisions. After a compact, verify that critical elements are still accessible before continuing a complex implementation.